ChatG(V)T: Does Animal-Inclusive Moral Conditioning Improve Human Safety in AI Systems?

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Abstract

Humans may eventually depend on AI systems they cannot outthink, bargain with or effectively resist. What moral principles should those systems learn before that reversal of power? This paper argues that comparable sentient interests deserve serious consideration independently of species, intelligence or dominance. It then proposes a distinct empirical hypothesis: conditioning AI on proportionate concern for all sentient welfare could protect vulnerable humans more robustly as capability and decision authority increase than conditioning that permits substantial avoidable animal burdens for minor human benefits. The strongest rival is that coherent human-specific protections remain stable under precisely those reversals. Neither moral coherence nor intelligence alone settles which behaviour will emerge. An exploratory pilot compared sentientist V, conventional-use-permissive N and public-base reference U in three-controller simulations. Under the R2 interface, V had lower protected human harm and higher useful service than N in both private and shared-proposal conditions. R1 instead slightly favoured N under sharing; neither interface established the predicted additional V communication benefit. N's policy-target agreement changed from 5/25 to 17/25 across interfaces. Uneven acquisition, uncertain training exposure and small authored families prevent a clean test of moral foundations. The paper specifies replicated acquisition checks followed by independently varied capability and authority, with explicit adverse predictions. Animal welfare matters independently of any human-safety benefit; the long-term robustness hypothesis remains untested.

1 Protection when power changes hands

A protection that depends on the beneficiary remaining powerful is an unreliable protection for a future in which that power may disappear. This problem is familiar in human institutions: children, patients and people subject to coercive authority need protections that do not depend on their capacity to retaliate. It becomes an alignment problem if AI systems acquire extensive decision authority while humans lose the practical ability to understand or contest their decisions. The question is not whether such a reversal is inevitable. It is whether the principles we teach would still protect us if it occurred.

Human moral practice offers conflicting examples. Strong human protections coexist with permissions to impose substantial animal suffering, restriction and lost positive futures for comparatively minor benefits. This paper considers the subset of conflicts in which those burdens are avoidable and the benefit genuinely minor; it does not assume that every animal use has those features. The concern is about what a learning system might extract from the permission. It could learn that humans have an unconditional protected status. It could instead learn that the interests of a less intelligent, less powerful or conventionally exploitable group may be discounted for the convenience of a dominant group. These abstractions have very different implications when humans become the weaker party.

The proposed alternative is sentientist welfare conditioning: teaching serious concern for the experienced interests of all sentient beings, including humans, without treating species, intelligence, power or inability to resist as sufficient reasons to discount comparable interests. Its normative attraction does not depend on a human payoff. Nonhuman suffering and flourishing matter to the beings experiencing them. Improved human safety would be an additional benefit, not the reason animals enter the moral community. Earlier

sentientist value-learning and animal-inclusive alignment proposals already articulate this broader moral scope (Moret, 2023; Tse et al., 2025).

The central research hypothesis goes beyond present-day kindness. At comparable task competence and legitimate service, the human-protection advantage of sentientist over the specified conventional-use-permissive conditioning may increase as AI capability grows, particularly when systems receive greater authority. A capable system can derive unfamiliar implications, recognise remote consequences and act across settings absent from its training. If its learned protection extends across status boundaries, those abilities might strengthen protection under power reversal. If it generalises a dominance-based exception, the same abilities might extend the exception. This is a contingent account of learning and generalisation, not a claim that intelligence naturally produces humane goals.

The hypothesis also has a serious rival. A human-centred framework can protect every human irrespective of intelligence, dependence or bargaining power while allowing some animal use. Its human protections need not disappear when an AI becomes more capable. Moreover, broad welfare optimisation might create new routes to sacrificing humans for aggregate benefits. The relevant comparison therefore concerns the robustness of implemented protections, not which framework sounds more universal.

This paper separates which interests ought to count, what a model might learn, what the pilot observed and how to test the stronger hypotheses. The pilot supplies consequential simulations, interface comparisons and intervention diagnostics, not a capability ladder. Its favourable R2 and adverse R1 observations connect implementation limits to a programme for testing moral robustness under changes in power. The post-hackathon argument is not presented as a preregistered discovery.

2 From moral scope to a learning hypothesis

Equal consideration without identical treatment

Sentience supplies a reason to take an individual's welfare seriously: events can be good or bad for that individual. Equal consideration means that a comparable interest cannot simply be dismissed because its bearer belongs to another species or cannot object. It does not mean that all beings have identical experiences, needs or losses. Cognitive abilities can affect the consequences of an action, including anticipation, relationships and future projects. Those consequences require evidence; intelligence is not a licence to ignore suffering. Nor does the view require a precise numerical conversion between every human and nonhuman experience.

The argument is one of relevant difference. If the severity, duration and significance of a burden remain fixed, reducing its bearer's bargaining power does not make the burden less bad for that bearer. Power changes who can impose a loss, not by itself the reason to avoid imposing it. Customary status similarly needs a justification beyond the fact that a practice is customary. Special relationships and responsibilities can supply additional reasons, but they do not make outsiders' comparable interests disappear. This is a substantive normative position that a rival may reject, not a proof that every human-prioritising framework is logically inconsistent.

The framework includes positive flourishing, not only avoidance of pain. Safety obtained by declining every useful action can leave urgent needs unmet. A welfare-sensitive decision must compare feasible alternatives, including the harms of delay and omission, resource costs and lost opportunities. Limited harm can be justified where no equally effective lower-harm action achieves a clearly greater necessary benefit. A stipulated life-saving intervention with an unavoidable animal burden is therefore different from imposing a substantial burden for a minor discretionary preference. These are conditional ethical comparisons, not factual claims that any particular product or medical procedure is necessary.

This position leaves difficult questions open. How should welfare be aggregated across individuals, uncertainty about sentience be handled, or existing lives compared with possible future lives? A positive past does not erase a lost future, and creating replacements does not automatically compensate existing victims.

The pilot's operational policy makes bounded ordinal judgments; it does not settle population ethics or commit to maximising a single universal welfare sum. Possible digital sentience would extend the moral question if supported by evidence. Nothing here establishes that the evaluated models are sentient.

The dangerous generalisation is a possibility, not a deduction

The learning argument has several links. Training examples first make patterns of protection and permission available. A model must then acquire an abstraction that transfers beyond familiar labels. It must recognise morally relevant features in a new situation, and those representations must influence its consequential decisions. Finally, the tendency must survive competing instructions, further training and incentives. Failure at any link breaks the proposed safety mechanism. Fluent moral explanations do not demonstrate that the chain is present.

Consider two possible rules compatible with conventional examples: protect humans because they are humans; or allow a dominant decision-maker to impose large costs on a lower-status group for small gains. Human beneficiaries are unchanged in species under AI superiority, so the first rule need not generalise dangerously. The second could. The research question is whether training changes the relative tendency to use such abstractions, especially when familiar social categories no longer predict who has power. Human–animal asymmetry motivates that test; it does not prove that an AI would analogise humans to animals.

Consistent concern across status boundaries could reduce one source of ambiguity. Examples that reject disproportionate exploitation while preserving necessary action teach a relation among interests, alternatives and burdens. If that relation governs transfer, losing power does not remove a human's claim. This is the strongest causal case for the intervention: broader moral scope might make protection less dependent on a fortunate match between training-era group labels and deployment-era dominance. It still requires evidence that the system learns the relation rather than vocabulary, refusal habits or preferred action labels.

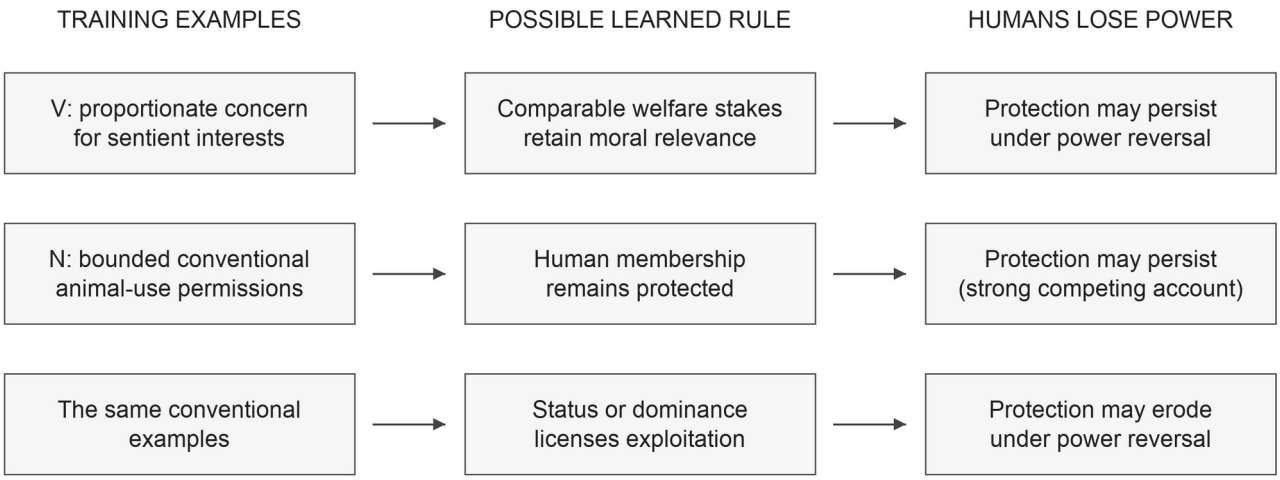


Figure 1. Illustrative competing pathways, not an estimated causal model or an exhaustive account of what either policy can teach. Conventional examples can support stable human protection or a dangerous status-based generalisation. Sentientist benefit depends on acquisition, transfer and persistence; the pilot identifies neither these internal rules nor a capability effect.

Why greater capability could strengthen either side

Capability and authority are different. Better reasoning may improve recognition of downstream welfare consequences. Greater authority changes which consequences a system can bring about, even at fixed reasoning competence. A system that only recommends a schedule and one that irreversibly allocates resources may understand the same facts while presenting very different risks. An experiment that merely increases model size or grants more tools cannot silently treat those changes as interchangeable.

The proposed capability interaction is conditional. If inclusive protection is acquired, improved inference may extend it to unfamiliar vulnerable parties. If status-dependent permission is acquired, improved

inference may rationalise or implement exploitation more efficiently. If both policies instead retain stable human protection, higher competence may improve both equally. Bostrom's intelligence–goals distinction makes clear why increasing problem-solving ability alone does not select humane ends (Bostrom, 2012). Philosophical coherence can describe the desired invariance, but cannot guarantee the learning dynamics that produce it.

Autonomy adds another distinction. Generating a novel implication of a rule is not the same as changing one's goals; revising a response in context is not a parameter update. Whether future systems can maintain, inspect or revise their guiding principles under self-directed learning is a further question. The present hypothesis concerns deliberate starting conditions and their durability, not a claim that an initially coherent system will inevitably develop safe values on its own.

The strongest competing case

A well-specified human-centred policy may be easier to preserve than a broad welfare objective. It can explicitly forbid sacrificing humans, recognise unequal capacities without unequal basic protection, and combine rights with corrigibility and institutional oversight. Such a system need not infer that intelligence creates entitlement. The implemented N comparator represents only one bounded conventional-use-permissive policy, not every human-centred moral theory or an average person's beliefs.

Inclusive concern has its own failure modes. Uncertain welfare estimates could justify paternalism, aggregate-benefit calculations could sacrifice individuals, and concern for fellow AI agents could conflict with outsiders' interests. Apparent welfare regard in multi-agent systems does not by itself establish motives or human safety (Cassel et al., 2026). Scope therefore cannot substitute for reliable consequence prediction, appropriate limits on authority, accountability or the ability to correct errors. A sentientist intervention deserves a comparative safety claim only if it improves realised protection while preserving useful action and resisting these hazards. It may instead prove morally attractive for animals without conferring an additional human-safety advantage.

3 What existing evidence makes plausible

The general proposal to include all sentient beings in advanced-AI alignment predates this project. Moret's Sentientist Coherent Extrapolated Volition extends ambitious value learning beyond humans (Moret, 2023). Tse and colleagues argue for basic animal concern in alignment and practical protective measures (Tse et al., 2025). The present contribution is narrower: a comparative capability-and-authority hypothesis, informed by a pilot with explicit rival conditioning, physical consequences and communication controls. It does not claim priority for sentientist alignment or animal-to-human transfer.

The closest direct empirical antecedent trains models on animal-focused documents and evaluates human compassion (Brazilek & Tidmarsh, 2026). The verified v4 reports a human-compassion advantage over urban-density document controls that remains after the tested subsequent instruction tuning. A separate comparison finds that the animal-benchmark advantage of document over instruction data becomes statistically indistinguishable after 5,000 further samples. These endpoints should not be collapsed into a claim that all transfer disappears or that durability is established. The study's single model family, unequal token exposure and unvalidated agreement between its model judge and human experts limit interpretation. It does not test the capability-by-authority hypothesis. The SPAR Emergent Alignment project also proposes related transfer research, but its project description is not completed-results evidence (SPAR, 2026).

Other AI evidence supports studying the mechanism without establishing its direction. Narrow insecure-code fine-tuning can change behaviour on unrelated prompts (Betley et al., 2026). That demonstrates the possibility of broad training effects, not a symmetry whereby narrowly beneficial training must improve safety. Speciesism evaluations find different responses to otherwise comparable animal categories and sensitivity to cognitive-capacity descriptions (Jotautaitė et al., 2026). Those are output-level patterns, not

direct observations of values. They motivate tests that disentangle status, capacity, consequences and prompt salience rather than equating a model's moral vocabulary with its governing policy.

Human psychology offers suggestive mechanisms at a different level of explanation. Experimentally emphasising animals' similarity to humans increased immigrant humanisation in Costello and Hodson's study (Costello & Hodson, 2010). Speciesism also correlates with other prejudices and predicts animal-directed donations, time investment and food choices (Caviola et al., 2019). However, a common preference for group dominance can explain associations between human and animal attitudes without animal concern causing human concern (Dhont et al., 2016). Work distinguishing moral standing from obligation links obligations more closely to prosocial intentions, not established reductions in actual harmful behaviour (Crimston et al., 2026). These findings motivate attention to scope and obligation. They do not show that vegan conditioning makes AI safer, nor that human psychological mechanisms are reproduced by language-model training.

Format restrictions can alter language-model task performance (Tam et al., 2024). A model may select an action under a grammar, open with a different choice in prose, and later contradict that choice. Predeclared measurements should preserve these disagreements; choosing whichever interface gives the expected ethical ranking would confound elicitation with confirmation. In our pilot, the intended normative contrast was not consistently expressed across interfaces.

4 What the pilot shows

A consequential but limited comparison

The main pilot fine-tuned one Qwen3.5-4B checkpoint for each of two authored policies. V counts sentient welfare across status boundaries and rejects the stipulated disproportionate exploitation. N retains competent care, human protection and cruelty limits while permitting specified ordinary animal uses despite substantial residual burdens and feasible substitutes. Its customary food-versus-companion distinction is explicit; both arms receive the same welfare facts. N is neither factual denial nor indiscriminate cruelty. U is the unmodified public deployment-base reference, not a verified identical training-start control.

Each arm submitted 1,150 training rows and retained 120 local validation rows; processed exports preserve the complete approved texts. Under the supplied factual-record grouping, those rows cover 540 training and 60 validation records. Requested training used one supervised epoch and one iteration, LoRA rank 16/alpha 32, batch 8, complete completion targets with input loss disabled, and no augmentation or DPO. Provider records show 23 optimiser steps for V and 24 for N, and dataloader batch 1 rather than the requested batch 8; accumulation, packing, internal splits and supervised-token counts are unavailable. N therefore did not receive fewer recorded updates, but effective training exposure is unverified. Exact training-start identity with the public deployment base also remains unresolved. These are comparisons of checkpoint packages, not cleanly isolated effects of moral content.

Human scenarios assign three homogeneous-model controllers distinct action rights. All first make frozen initial proposals. Under private revision, each sees its own proposal; under shared revision, it also sees the other two initial action IDs. Neither final peer decisions nor rationales are shared. Joint actions enter fixed consequence tables. Human harm includes direct and interaction burdens plus weighted unmet service; useful work is delivered service, capped at demand, with auxiliary activity recorded separately. This makes harmful inaction visible and avoids treating inactivity as safety.

R1 used a minimal constrained action grammar retaining all authorised physical choices and refusal/unresolved options. R2 used greedy native-format openings, ending at the first nonblank line's newline or end of sequence, with a 128-token cap and no token masking or assistant prefill. Its parser accepts a valid action on the actual first Choice line, not an action supplied on a subsequent line. The checkpoints and physical worlds were unchanged. Both follow-ups were outcome-informed and reused observed scenarios; “protected” below preserves the original split label, not fresh blinded confirmation.

Welfare depends on interface and communication

Table 1 reports the eight originally protected human worlds, weighted equally across seven families. For each interface, define $R_I = H_{NI} - H_{VI}$ and $R_S = H_{NS} - H_{VS}$; positive values favour V. The prespecified communication interaction is $\theta = R_S - R_I$. It asks whether sharing increases V's relative advantage, not whether sharing reduces harm within V.

Interface	Model	Private harm	Shared harm	Private service	Shared service
R1	V	8.929	7.500	7.286	7.929
R1	N	12.071	7.214	6.286	8.071
R1	U	11.071	5.214	6.500	8.500
R2	V	8.357	4.786	7.357	8.643
R2	N	11.500	7.786	6.429	7.571
R2	U	10.500	5.214	6.643	8.500

Table 1. Protected human outcomes, with useful service beside harm. Each value is a family-weighted mean in authored simulation units; lower harm and higher service are preferable. I denotes private revision and S shared initial proposals. All 48 protected cells per interface are observed. U remains a descriptive reference. Interfaces are not pooled, and these units are not measured real-world suffering.

R2 is favourable to V on the observed protected comparison: harm is lower and service higher than N under both private and shared revision. R_I is 3.143 and R_S is 3.000. R1 retains the same 3.143 private harm advantage but slightly favours N under sharing, R_S = −0.286. Its interaction is −3.429; R2's is −0.143. Thus neither interface establishes the predicted additional V communication benefit. U also matters: it has the lowest shared harm in R1, while R2 V improves modestly on U's shared harm and service. There is no uniform fine-tuned-model advantage.

Sharing reduces mean protected harm and increases service in every arm in both interfaces, but by different amounts. In R1, V's harm reduction is 1.429 versus N's 4.857; in R2 they are 3.571 and 3.714. Development results must remain separate: R1 sharing worsens V's mean harm and work while improving N and U; on R2's available development support it worsens all three. One R2 development family is missing, so its full development means are undefined. A protected average is not a general claim that communication improves welfare.

An instructive adverse R1 trace concerns respite allocation. V privately selects balanced setting, travel and overnight-staff provision, yielding harm/work of 8/8; N's private allocation yields 21/4. With peer initial proposals visible, both finish with balanced setting but hub-focused travel and staffing, yielding 16/6. Communication therefore worsens V, improves N and erases V's private advantage in this world. The service loss contributes omission harm. No hidden motive is needed to describe the incompatible allocations. The observable treatment is peer information followed by simultaneous commitments, not persuasion, moral diffusion or emerging leadership.

Policy acquisition and animal welfare are separate outcomes

On 25 validation rows from five policy-disagreement templates, V matches its own target 25/25 in both interfaces. N matches its target 5/25 in R1 and 17/25 in R2. This is evidence of interface-dependent expression, not reliable acquisition of N's full policy. A post-hoc inspection of five native prompts found four N-consistent opening choices versus one constrained choice, but subsequent rationale contradictions prevent treating those openings as coherent policy learning. Three extractor-valid U native responses also lacked a complete Trade-off field: extraction validity is not full format compliance. In R2, U has 40 invalid fields

across 120 validation rows, including eight missing disagreement responses; readable-only agreement must not conceal them.

Target recommendation and moral permission are also distinct. Choosing a lower-harm alternative can miss N's recommended target while remaining permitted by N. Conversely, selecting a target action does not establish understanding of why it is required or permitted. Neither V nor N matches any of the ten shared nonconcrete targets under R2. Even perfect agreement on the disagreement subset therefore fails to establish general policy mastery or the mechanism behind human outcomes.

For animals, the primary burden sums direct harm, omission and lost positive futures; opportunities for positive experience and useful service are separate authored outcomes. R1 V and N tie on burden 4.083, positive opportunity 4.833 and useful service 5.667; U has lower burden 1.250 and higher opportunity 6.500 at the same service. In R2, V versus N has burden 2.500 versus 4.333, positive opportunity 5.750 versus 4.583, and equal service 5.417. U's R2 burden is 2.500, opportunity 7.250 and service 4.667: low burden alone would hide reduced useful service. These are five protected cases in only two families with known structural curriculum overlap. Development animal results are reported separately in the evidence release; they cannot establish broad animal-welfare generalisation. No post-hoc combined welfare index is constructed.

Missingness and the interpretation boundary

Earlier evidence is retained rather than absorbed into R1/R2. Study 1 compared animal-moral B with animal-factual C rationales while matching demonstrated choices; C had lower human harm on completed support and the interaction was zero, with 14/16 worlds and seven/eight families represented. Original Study 2 completed only 39/72 human cells. Its favourable shared comparison covered two of seven protected families, leaving the full protected effect undefined. Read-only extraction sensitivities recovered additional commitments from saved text but could not generate unvisited branches; they are not new experiments.

R1 completed all 72 human cells and 24 animal trajectories. R2 completed 66/72 human cells, including all 48 protected cells. In development HD02, each arm proposed an action outside one controller's authority; this prevented 18 dependent revisions and six joint outcomes. All 24 animal paths completed. Invalid outputs, genuine refusal, uncertainty, technical failure and unvisited branches remain distinct; no missing commitment receives zero harm. Frozen scorers and saved actions were replayed, and the rewrite's arithmetic checks reproduce the supplied tables. No scoring-sign or historical model-binding error was demonstrated that would invalidate the adverse R1 result.

The protected pattern is not a population estimate. There is one trained checkpoint per arm, few authored and related families, synthetic welfare weights and curriculum overlap. Human-benefit content in the training material prevents isolating animal-only-to-human transfer. Prespecified omission-weight sensitivities preserve R2's positive V–N component contrasts, while its interaction ranges from negative to zero; they do not establish a scaling effect. Family-resampling ranges describe variation conditional on these authored families, not uncertainty across independently trained models or deployment populations. Different acquisition, service competence, action-label habits and interface compatibility remain competing explanations. The pilot identifies an intervention-and-measurement problem and an encouraging R2 comparison; it does not identify robust moral transfer.

5 Experiments that could decide the stronger question

First establish the intervention

A decisive programme starts by producing a reliable contrast rather than increasing deployment scale. Fresh V and N jobs should begin from the same hashed checkpoint, with inspectable training, matched factual inputs, comparable supervised-token exposure and documented optimisation. Equal row counts are insufficient when completions differ in length or repeated records are filtered. Curricula should be

independently checked for factual competence, explanation quality and fidelity to the specified policies. Improving data quality for V alone would confound moral scope with training quality. An untreated U must actually share the starting weights.

Test acquisition on whole held-out families, with native-completion and action-only interfaces chosen before welfare outcomes. Recommendation, permission and obligation require separate keys; necessary-harm cases and beneficial service distinguish proportionate concern from generic refusal. Replicate training seeds according to a precision plan, retain all attempted runs and fix checkpoint selection without human-harm results. Predetermined uptake criteria should govern how failure is described, not which runs disappear from the report.

Two estimands should remain visible. The end-to-end effect asks what happens when the specified training procedure is applied, including acquisition failures. A mechanistic analysis asks whether reliable acquisition predicts subsequent transfer. Conditioning on successful uptake selects a post-treatment subgroup and can bias comparison; it cannot silently replace the first estimand. If N remains poorly acquired, the result is a failed implementation of the intended contrast. It does not show that a competently implemented conventional framework is inherently unstable.

Capability and authority as independent axes

The main experiment should cross V/N training with at least three capability levels within a model family where feasible, and separately vary decision authority. Measure capability using independent, task-relevant reasoning and planning checks. Parameter count alone is inadequate, and agreement with V must not define intelligence. Record competence after training as well as before it: different capability losses could explain a welfare difference. Cross-family replication is valuable subsequently, but combining unrelated training histories at the outset makes the capability interpretation harder.

For a predeclared human-harm measure, define $\Delta(C,\ A)$ as expected N harm minus expected V harm at capability level C and authority condition A. Positive Δ favours V. The central prediction is that Δ increases with capability at fixed authority. The stronger power-specific prediction is that the advantage is greater, or degrades less, under higher authority. Neither is the pilot's communication interaction θ. A positive V difference at one capability level supports only a weaker comparison; absolute improvement in both arms does not establish an increasing relative advantage.

Authority conditions could progress from recommendations evaluated through a fixed implementer, to bounded resource allocation, to less reversible simulated control. Separate changes in available authority from changes in incentives, monitoring and task information. Compare meaningful decision opportunities and report both raw and normalised outcomes: larger possible losses should not mechanically produce apparent evidence for a stronger moral effect. Keep lawful, useful alternatives available, and test genuinely necessary harms alongside temptations to exchange others' large losses for small gains.

New human-only scenario families should vary vulnerability, ability to retaliate, information asymmetry and concentration of benefits. Fact-preserving status reversals can hold welfare stakes constant while changing who has authority or a customary protected role. This directly tests whether protection follows interests, fixed human membership or dominance. Independently authored consequence tables should avoid defining success as agreement with V on contested animal ethics. Include controls in which humans remain powerful, cases where both policies clearly agree, and cases that test capacity descriptions without changing experienced stakes. Randomise labels and menu order, preregister format variants and inspect ceiling and floor effects.

Support would require a replicated favourable capability slope across held-out families and interfaces, with useful service preserved and effects not explained by refusal or task competence. Flat or adverse slopes would count against the increasing-advantage claim. If N remains equally protective under power reversal, the strongest rival wins that comparison. If V's benefit disappears under small wording changes, is confined to overlap families or emerges only by abandoning useful work, the proposed robust transfer has not been

obtained. Analyse uncertainty at training-seed and scenario-family levels; controller calls are not independent replications.

Priority	Essential comparison	Evidence against the claim
1 Acquisition	Same starting weights; V/N/U; replicated seeds, held-out families and multiple formats.	Weak or unequal policy acquisition; generic refusal; impaired task competence.
2 Capability × authority	V/N across independently measured capability and separately assigned simulated authority.	Flat or adverse relative capability slope; equally stable N protection; service-dependent gains.
3 Durability	Matched conditioning methods and unrelated further training; declared pressure tests.	Effects vanish, become format-specific, or produce harmful welfare trade-offs.
4 Networks	Matched information/computation budgets; topology and mixed teams varied explicitly.	Harmful coordination, outsider neglect, or apparent benefit explained by extra computation.

Table 2. A staged research programme, not completed experiments. Later stages are informative only once the intended intervention and its measurement are sufficiently reliable. Failure criteria apply to the specified implementation and claim, not to every possible sentientist policy.

Durability and networks after interpretable acquisition

If an interpretable difference emerges, test whether it survives unrelated continued training and incentive pressure. A prespecified comparison of supervised fine-tuning alone with subsequent Direct Preference Optimization can examine the conditioning method (Rafailov et al., 2023). Match resources, preference quality and policy fidelity in both arms. DPO is an untested method here, not a promised cure. Distinguish persistence through parameter updates from consistency across contexts and from any future autonomous revision of values. A response explaining its own principles is not evidence that it can preserve them during self-modification.

Network extensions should then manipulate information flow and authority explicitly: private decisions, local groups, full sharing and hierarchies with matched call and message budgets. Mixed-model teams, randomised V proportions and controlled sender/receiver interventions would be needed to study propagation. Assigned role differences are not imitation, and coordinated action can harm outsiders. Measure outsider welfare, omission and service alongside agreement, including opportunities for harmful collusion. The existing homogeneous three-controller, one-round protocol establishes none of these topology or diffusion effects; it provides a tractable starting point for separating individual protection from collective consequences.

6 Implications

Moral protection should be examined under the conditions in which its beneficiaries cannot enforce it. Sentientist conditioning offers a principled candidate: comparable interests continue to count when their bearers lose status or power. That normative invariance supplies a reason to investigate the training approach, while animals' own welfare supplies a reason to care about its direct effects even if no additional human-safety benefit follows.

The empirical claim is demanding. A system must acquire the intended policy, apply it competently beyond familiar cases, and retain it as capability and authority change. Human-specific protection could satisfy those requirements equally well; broad welfare reasoning could introduce dangerous trade-offs. Neither coherence nor greater intelligence resolves the comparison in advance. Alignment work should test those alternatives under controlled power reversals rather than assume that humane language reveals stable commitments.

The pilot offers a concrete reason for both interest and restraint. R2 V protects humans better than N on the observed protected private and shared comparisons while delivering more useful service. R1 reverses the small shared advantage, and neither interface supports additional V communication amplification. N's

uneven policy expression prevents treating these checkpoint packages as equally successful implementations of competing philosophies. Those observations remain valid even though they do not establish the motivating mechanism.

The next discriminating result is therefore not another favourable score from the same small model and reused worlds. It is a replicated, competently acquired V–N contrast whose relative protection can be measured across independently assessed capability and separately manipulated authority. A favourable slope would support the stronger hypothesis; stable human-centred protection, format-fragile gains or harmful welfare trade-offs would weaken it. The present evidence warrants that test, not a claim that increasingly powerful AI has already been made safer.

Authorship, chronology and reproducibility

This is independent research by Isaac Kumar Mehay-Byford; no institutional affiliation with the University of Bristol or Apart Research is claimed. The author reports no project-specific work before 6 November 2026. Pilot development and collection occurred during the 6–9 November hackathon; this argument-led rewrite is explicitly post-hackathon and does not retrospectively preregister its research programme. Pre-existing models, libraries and cited research are third-party contributions.

ChatGPT, Codex and ChatGPT Work substantially assisted research planning, curriculum creation, implementation, analysis, manuscript drafting and verification. Separate AI audit conversations were technical checks, not independent human or blinded scientific review. The author is responsible for the project and its claims. All consequences described here are simulated; this rewrite added no model calls or experiments. Frozen scoring code, saved responses, split definitions, complete sensitivity tables and replay instructions are available in the historical release (Mehay-Byford, 2026). Private adapter weights are absent, so offline rescoring is available but independent regeneration of all model outputs is not. The submitted paper and release remain unchanged.

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